who has spent five decades in the Congress. He has performed various organisational roles, served as minister in the Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi and P.V. Narasimha Rao governments and has enjoyed the trust of generations of Gandhis. Gehlot is also a prominent leader from the north, where the party has performed abysmally in the previous two Lok Sabha polls. Adept in the art of realpolitik, he was instrumental in the party's resurgent performance in the 2017 Gujarat assembly polls and is now again election in-charge in the state this year.

Gehlot is also an OBC leader, just like Prime Minister Narendra Modi, which may stand the party in good stead, as the OBC vote bank is considered a swing factor in any election. He also shares a warm equation with most Opposition leaders (indeed much more so than Rahul), which will be essential if the party is to build an alliance to challenge the BJP in 2024. Gehlot's access to business leaders could also help solve the party's funds crunch.

Tharoor's biggest challenge is that he will be the rebel candidate against the one backed by the Gandhi family

That said, his electoral record does not inspire confidence. As incumbent CM, he has never been able to lead the Congress to victory in Rajasthan. And in the past two Lok Sabha polls, the Congress drew a blank in the state. Most importantly, however, he is seen as part of the old guard, a symbol of the Congress inertia that has led to its decline. His elevation, critics say, is unlikely to enthuse either party workers or voters.

In contrast, Tharoor brings a whiff of freshness to the party, thanks to his professional accomplishments and popularity among the educated middle class. A career diplomat, who worked with the United Nations for nearly three decades, an acclaimed author and public intellectual, Tharoor made a lateral entry into the party in 2009, thanks to Sonia, and was made a Union minister straight away.

The suave and articulate Congressman has a great appeal among the aspirational middle class, which played a key role in the evolution of the BJP. Tharoor's vibrant social media presence and massive following could also help the party build an alternative narrative in a domain where the BJP always has an edge over the Congress.

Where Tharoor falters is in his understanding of the party structure and support within. The veterans are unlikely to cooperate with him; even several G23 leaders are unwilling to accept him as president. Indeed, even leaders in his home state Kerala have come out and said they will not support him. Critics also cite his propensity to get into controversies, thanks to his public comments. But the biggest challenge is that he will be the rebel candidate against the one backed by the Gandhi family.

And that's what makes it a battle of unequals. Anyway, whoever becomes the next Congress president will have a gargantuan mountain to climb. He or she must revive a moribund party organisation, build a poll-ready narrative and start winning elections. Very few will envy the winner in this. ■

LANGUAGE DIVIDE

SPEAKING OF BEING EQUAL

By Amarnath K. Menon

'India, not Hindia'. As a war cry, that's a softer and refined version of what rang out from the same geography of dissent back in the 1960s, when it played close to a secessionist line. But in its rejection of Hindi as national language, it is as resolute. There's another difference: this time Tamil Nadu isn't alone. The six decades in between have seen a growing awareness—and positive evaluation—of India as an incredibly rich repository of linguistic cultures. The idea that it's this richness that deserves to be conferred with an official halo, rather than the old notion of a unitary and internally colonial nation, now sits well with more and more Indians. Thus, as Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin takes the campaign for equal language rights into the rival camp, he speaks to a different India.

That's why Stalin's call for a major reform to make all 22 languages in the Eighth Schedule official languages of the Union government, on par with Hindi, is resonating well beyond Tamil Nadu. Chief ministers and leaders from several non-Hindi states now echo that demand and call for abandoning the pre-eminent status given to Hindi. This spirit is firmly entrenched in Karnataka, Kerala, Maharashtra, West Bengal, and far beyond in civil society. Twitter campaigns such as #StopHindiImposition bear witness to it, as do new federal organisations like the Campaign for Language Equality and Rights (CLEAR). Strikingly, it even strikes a chord among those bearing allegiance to neglected languages within the 'Hindi belt'.

Stalin's demand comes in the wake of Union home minister Amit Shah privileging Hindi in remarks at the All India Official Languages Conference in Surat on September 14. Speaking on the occasion of Hindi Divas, Shah said other Indian languages would prosper only when Hindi